THE BURGESS PERSIAN LETTERS

Edited by BENJAMIN SCHWARTZ

PART VIII — *Conclusion*

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Gul Ahek near Tehran, June 29, 1849*

I enclose you a document to enable you to act for me with regard to the property left by my poor mother;[123] I doubt whether this will do but we can not get any regular powers of attorney in Persia and if such a thing is necessary you had better send me out one for me to sign here. Messrs Scott Bell Co of New Broad Street London, who know me as one of Cormick's executors and who have been in the habit of sending powers of attorney to Persia about Cormick's estate business, will tell you how this ought to be done. If my uncle pays you the money you can pay it into either Scott Bell C° or F. Ede and Sons so that I may draw against it if I want it.

I have come out of town for a day or two to this village which is situated towards the mountains and is the place of the British Mission and the other English pass the summer months [here] to avoid the great heats and bad climate of Tehran; I have not yet moved out of town because the King is still at his summer palace just outside the walls, and those in the service are obliged to be near, and it is uncertain whether he will go up towards the hills during the summer or not. I shall try to get leave during the Ramazan (the Mahomedan fast month) and come and live with my friend Abbott the consul; this month falls this year, from the 20*th* July to 19*th* Aug*t* and the King talks of going up to the hills during this month, if so I do not think I shall be obliged to go with him, as his will not be a standing camp. I hear there are some most beautiful places in the range of mountains to the north, with some fine trout streams and a very cool climate. I enjoy coming out here for a day or two very much and feel like a cockney come to Richmond for the Sunday.

The war in Khorassan still continues indeed I am sorry to say that our troops do not appear to be any nearer putting down this insurrection than six months ago, except that the rebel chief the Salar is pretty much confined to the capital of the province Meshed. Until this war is finished we shall not get on well, the governors of the other provinces will not send in their revenues regularly, nor will the people pay them, until we are fairly masters of Khorassan. This makes the government very hard up for money and consequently people are not regularly paid.

[123] A letter from Edward addressed to his uncle, George Ridsdale, and certified by Richard W. Stevens, British consul at Tabriz, authorizes George Burgess, Edward's brother, to act as his (E's) agent in the receipt of money or other property left by their mother, Frances Burgess.

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A new governor Hunizah Meerza one of the King's uncles has been appointed governor general of Azerbijan. I thought of trying to get sent to Tabreez with him, but have now given up the idea, for many reasons one of which is that I do not think they would let me go, and I might vex the king and his minister by asking. Otherwise my four hundred tomauns a year there, would be good as six here, because that is such a cheap place, and then I should most likely get extra pay from the govr genl and allowances. But I have determined to try my luck here for some time to come at least.

I asked you some time ago whether Persian carpets would sell in America. Perhaps you never saw any. We have nothing in England so good and durable, but on account of their shape (paralelogram) they are not much used in Europe, except the small ones which are used as rugs these cost about from S30/ to 40/ at Tabreez.

How does your trade go on, where do you live? in the town of New York or near it? is it not from the quantity of steamers a place something like Liverpool?

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tehran, February 21, 1850*

How is the climate of New York during the summer, I suppose hot, and very cold in the winter. Are you much troubled with mosquitoes during the hot months as we are here. In fact on all the plains of Persia these unpleasant little animals abound, that is wherever the cultivation is carried on by turning a stream of water over the ground to irrigate it, as this forms an artificial marsh and produces mosquitoes fevers and agues and other disagreeables.

Has the gold from California made much difference in the trade of New York? The papers say not, at least as far as the money market is concerned. But by degrees the people collecting there must cause a brisk trade in manufactures.

Persia is still a good deal unsettled and Meshed the capital of Khorassan is yet in the hands of the rebels.[124] The government have sent an immense force against this city but as yet they have not been able to take it. Partly owing to its being considered a holy place and both soldiers and officers being unwilling to fight against it. Its sanctity however would not prevent the soldiers from plundering it if they could get into the town.

My friend Mr Abbott our consul here has gone on a journey to the south of Persia from whence he will return by way of Bushur, Busora, Baghdad to Kermanshah and here. The government pay his expenses and he is to make up a commercial report on the trade of the countries he passes through.

[124] Salar withstood a siege of eighteen months in Meshed, at the end of which period he was handed over to the besiegers by the townspeople. He was barbarously tortured in a vain attempt to make him reveal the hiding place of his treasure, and then strangled.

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If the king remains here next summer I intend trying to hire a very pretty orchard with a grove of large trees in it to encamp in during the hot months. This place belongs to the government and the custom is that in the spring the produce of the season is let out to the highest bidder; the fruit of this orchard may yield about six or eight pounds Str and I mean either to take it and have the amount charged to me on account of my pay or allowances and then I should have to relet the fruit or perhaps if the King or his minister if they are liberal, the one or the other may make me a present of the amount. I was in town last year until the end of July and fell ill accordingly.

Besides my monthly translations from the European newspapers I am now employed in making an abridged translation of a gazeteer. I do not know whether the King will have patience until I have done it or not as I am often set upon other work before I have finished that which I have in hand.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tehran, October 24, 1850*

I do not know whether you are aware that Charles left an illegitimate family in Persia, this consisted of the mother and two children a boy and a girl, the boy died in the spring of '41 of measles or rather diarrhea consequent on that disease. This family I have had for many years to support. The mother is a most respectable woman. Do not start; recollect that these sort of connections are looked upon in the East as a species of marriage. I should not have mentioned this affair at all but our niece Mary the girl above mentioned is now remarkably well married. Last spring the mother wrote to me from Tabreez asking my permission to allow Mary to marry a certain Ferramurz Khan, a major in the army and a man well to do in the world. Nargis (the mother) was affraid that I would not consent because this same Ferramurz Khan is a bigotted Roman Catholic. I wrote to Stevens our Consul at Tabreez (Or his brother George Stevens I forget which or both perhaps) where the family were to enquire, and be quite sure that the mother was not forcing the girl to marry a man twice her age, whom she might dislike, because he had a little money and rank. I also wrote, that as I had supported the family respectably so far, with God's help I would do so still, and by no means have the little girl forced into a match she did not like "as to Ferramurz Khan I know no harm about him except that he is a bigotted catholic, one who would burn us poor heretics without mercy if he could catch us, but as he is not likely to catch me, and if he did he is still less likely to burn his wife's uncle and as Mary is a catholic too, if she likes him I see no harm in the match" this is an extract from my letter as near as I can recollect it, and now I send you George Stevens' answer. I had written to him not to give my letter consenting to the match until he was thoroughly satisfied

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that there was no force in the matter; "My dear Burgess. I received last night your lines of the *3rd* instant and this morning I saw your niece and questioned her as to her future happiness. She agrees to take Ferramurz Khan as her lawful husband and moreover she says it is a match of her own making. I saw her all alone — so that it may not be said that her mother was with her. As I see no objection to Ferramurz Khan and as Dick" (his elder brother the consul) "is of the same opinion, and also as there is no chance of his burning his wife's uncle (unless he wants his father burnt in return), I, after questioning Mary gave her your letter for Nargis (the mother). The poor girl looked happy and I am sure she will make Ferramurz the same. I had not seen her since last July" (this was written last May) "and I was quite astonished to find her grown a big woman and what's more something exquisitely pretty." They were married about a month after this and I hear from, and of them, occasionally and they appear to be remarkably happy and well off. Mary was only just fourteen years old when she was married, (again do not be surprised, recollect that Shakespeare's Julia was just that age) and her husband must be about thirty or perhaps more. They now live at Ouroumia and not at Tabreez. I have mentioned this matter to you because I think it would amuse you, but I have never mentioned any thing about this family to my father; I may be wrong, but it appeared to me that it would show a want of delicacy, to write about his sons illegitimate family, to a father perhaps even a want of respect. Now that Charles' daughter is married I have less of that feeling, and I shall perhaps send this letter open to him. As to Charles, I suspect he neither knows, or cares any thing about the woman or his children and perhaps has forgot even their very existence, at least I know he has never written to enquire about them since he felt Persia; but I confess that her being so well married gives me great pleasure, for I should have been very willing to have had her married to any respectable tailor or carpenter when she had grown a little older; when I was at Tabreez as she lived near I often used to make her come and make tea for me, and I think she was fond of me, for rather more than two years ago when I was obliged to march to Tehran with the king she nearly cried her eyes out; I thought of bringing her and her mother here so as to have them near and be able to look after them better, but being married and settled at Ouroumia she is much better off.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tehran, April 22, 1851*

I am by no means certain that I have answered your kind letter of the 11*th* Nov*r* altho if I am not mistaken, I have written to you since its arrival because I think I recollect mentioning that the gov*t* had started a state gazette and made

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me the editor altho without any increase of pay or allowances as yet. (Our first number appeared on the 5th Feby and I received your letter on the 18th.)

You ask about my income and manner of life. My pay is four hundred tomauns a year (say about a hundred and eighty pounds) and I have an allowance for forage for my horses and house-rent. Soon after we arrived I was long in arrears now those arrears are paid up, except what was due to me before this king came to the throne which however I hope to get shortly. My employment is making out translations of the European news for the king and prime minister — these are about forty pages of Persian a month which is about equal to forty pages of English print the same size as a leading article in the papers and the pages are small quarto. Besides this I have to attend levees and other work and now I have the whole management of this newspaper on my shoulders.[125] So you see I have work enough. My friends are chiefly the officers of the British and Russian missions with many of whom I am on intimate terms. For the first week or two after the paper was started I was so harrassed that I did not know which way to turn, and one evening after I had been dining at Col Shiel's (our minister here) I went to Mr R. Thomson's the third attaché, and there [were] three or four of us there, and I thought we were to have a pleasant hour or two over our grog and songs, all free and easy, when Meerza Hussein Kouli the Persian secretary to the mission began criticising a passage in one of the articles in the gazette, upon a question of style. (In this however, I afterwards proved him wrong.) This rather annoyed me and as I had been hard at work at the paper all day I wished to hear no more about it, one of my friends perceiving this said "Why Burgess is vexed." I said, "I was but it has passed off in proof of which I will sing you a song" and I sang "Gaffer Gray Gaffer's son and their little jackass" which I dare say you recollect for our poor Mother used to sing it to us when we were children. Perhaps you may not recollect it for when you had attained an age to remember such things, misfortunes had come upon our family and our poor mother had not much spirits for singing. It is an old and very rare song with perhaps no great merit in it, but there is a verse in it peculiarly applicable to my being bothered by people from morning 'til night about the newspaper. I never heard any one sing it except our dear Mother.

Col and Mrs Shiel are both exceedingly kind to me, the lady plays the piano and sings prettily and when the Russians dine there we have some good music. They are all more or less musical and the greatest treat I have had was hearing

125 Cf. Robert B. M. Binning, *Journal of two years travel in Persia, etc.*, London, 1857, v. 2, p. 215, discussing the scarcity of Europeans in Teheran, "...but excepting two or three French and Italian shopkeepers, and one Englishman, who acts as translator to the Shah, and manages the only newspaper..." This was the first newspaper printed in Persia; its name was *Rusnama-i-waqayi'-i-ittifaqiyya* ("Journal of occasional happenings"), cf. E. G. Browne, *The Persian press and Persian journalism*, London, 1914, p. 8.

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the service chanted last week (passion week) and on last Sunday (Easter Sunday) at Prince Dolgorovki's (The Russian minister).

I see by the papers that the Count de Sartige formerly French minister Plenipo[y] here is now appointed in the same capacity at Washington. He is a Frenchman of the old school and if he should pass through New York and you can mannage to get presented to him he will I am sure receive you civilly. Or if you were to write him a note and say that as he had seen me in Persia you wished to wait upon him he would appoint a time and treat you kindly. Upon second thoughts I have written you a note to him. I have dined and breakfasted with him often when he was here, and as I know how anxious I am to see any one who has seen you, I think you will like to see a person who has seen me. The style of the note may appear to you formal but such are the forms, and with people of that rank, however civilly and even intimately they may treat humble people like you and I, those forms must be adhered to.[126] The note may also be the means of introducing you to some of the great people of New York and thereby forming useful commercial connections; if not I have had my trouble for nothing and you will have to pay the postage; that is all the harm that can be done.

I congratulate you most cordially on the birth of your daughter, I hope she may be the harbinger of a vast many more, sons and daughters. Long life to the father and Mother and her.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tehran, June 16, 1851*

I do not recollect whether I answered your questions about your friends in Persia or not. First Aliah, he is now in the service of Mr Ronald F. Thomson one of the attachés of the British mission. He is well off and has I think two wives, but about these matters we seldom enquire much in Persia. I gave him

126 Tehran 22 April 1851

To His Excellency
The Count de Sartige.

Sir,

I was much pleased to learn from the last months papers that your Excellency had been appointed Minister Plenipotentiary for France at Washington, and I beg to present to you my most sincere congratulations.

Presuming upon the favor and kindness which your Excellency always showed me when in Persia, I beg leave to present my brother Mr. George Burgess, and by allowing him the honor of waiting upon you, you will be doing a kindness to two brothers who have not met for nearly twenty years.

I am, with much respect,
Your Excellency's
Most obedient,
and very humble servant,
EDWARD BURGESS.

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your kind messages at one of our merry meetings when he had come in with his masters water pipe and he was delighted and sent all sorts of civil and dutiful messages in return, much more than I can translate in this letter; Codja Andrè is a clerk in the Post Office at Nuhshiwan (Russia). Dr Cormick is at Tabreez married to one of the most beautiful girls in the country; he has an income of about a thousand a year English money, besides the interest of his money in the funds. He is talking of asking for leave for England, to see the great exhibition[127] and also to pursue his medical studies in Europe. I ought to tell you that he has already passed his examinations as an apothecary surgeon and M. D. but medical study is his passion and he is actually thinking of getting leave for England for one or two years, by doing which he will have to give up his income all but about two hundred pounds a year, half of his net pay. John Cormick now a captain has left his regiment the 40*th* and exchanged into one under orders for India, where I suppose he has now arrived. So you see other people knock about the world besides you and I, even those who can well afford to stay at home. Captn McDonald died in the Punjaub last year, a natural death, notwithstanding his presentiment that he should die with his boots on. What a good amiable man he was, where did you see him? I believe I gave you a pretty good account of my own income and employment in my last letter but since that I have changed the day of the paper's coming out from Friday to Thursday, the first week this was very difficult. Monday Tuesday and Wednesday I, and my two clerks, had worked like mill-horses, when you may imagine my disgust on Wednesday evening at receiving a note from the printer saying the paper would be out on Thursday evening, that is too late for distribution. I immediately wrote him a note as follows. "Hadji Abdul Mahomed — if the paper is not out before 12 o'clock tomorrow I shall complain to the Govt and do my utmost to get a heavy fine inflicted upon you — so please yourself." The paper was out before eight the next morning. This same Hadji Abdul Mahomed appears to be a very respectable man and the best printer in Persia, but he is much too slow for Govt work with which he has had little to do and he requires spurring — as above.

I have received a letter from a man named "Ayer" Lowell Mass. U. S. with a box of what I suppose to be lozenges or some preparation for chest complaints begging me to present them to the King in his name. This I shall do without opening the box as I might not be able to pack it so well again. The King is now absent and will soon be at Ispahan and I shall forward the box to his chief physician and hope to get some return as an autograph letter medal or something else for Mr Ayer, of whom I know nothing. He has written me a vulgar letter and appears himself to be an ass.

[127] The World's Fair in the Crystal Palace, London.

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[EDWARD BURGESS TO HENRY BURGESS] *Tehran, February 19, 1852*

I am very much gratified to perceive that you take much interest, in my paper or rather the government Gazette managed by me. I was afraid that my writing in every letter about the paper might become tiresome; you are quite right in observing that the carrying on such a publication requires much caution, particularly with regard to the foreign news which I publish, otherwise England Russia or Turkey, the three governments with which Persia has most to do, might complain, give trouble to the government and get me into a mess. I have however gone on very well as yet and the longer the thing goes on the better I, and those employed under me, carry on the routine of the business.

My illness which I perhaps foolishly mentioned to you last autumn was nothing at all serious and has now left me, but after trying almost all the European medecines such as rhubarb magnesia soda etc without much success I found much benefit from the Persian treatment viz astringent acids particularly pommegranites and I now continue taking this delicious fruit occasionally although I have little occasion for it medecinally.

We are expecting another attaché to the Mission which I shall be glad of as we are so few English we are always glad of an addition to our party. Col Farrant now in England on leave will also most likely be back during the summer.

I should like you to see Sheffea Khan, the Persian Chargé d'affaires in London. He is not here considered a clever man, and never before held a higher place than that of Lt Colonel (unattached) and every one was much surprised at his being named Chargé d'affaires and that at such a court as London. I believe I told you in a former letter that my friend in his mission is Meerza Ibrahim the interpreter. I think it is probable that Sheffea Khan may now be recalled, his great protector was the late Ameer i Nizaum (the Prime Minister) and it is not likely this government will go on paying between three and four thousand pounds a year for a Chargé d'affaires at London when they can very well do without one. The Persian Government have also sent an expensive mission to St Petersburgh, this they will probably continue at least for some time to come.

My wife is quite well and sends her duty. I have found out that she is a good horse-woman for the other day as we were riding out, I proposed going to a place called Cheshma Allee a pretty place where there is an abundant spring of pure, clear, water gushing out from under a rock, and abounding with fish, and forgetting that ladies were not in the habit of riding across country I took a straight line and we had some little ditches to get over which she jumped beautifully.

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[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tehran, March 22, 1852*

I do not know whether you have heard that I was married last autumn to a Georgian lady of good family and thank God she makes me a most kind agreeable and affectionate wife. She is pretty and about thirty three years old. She has no money in property but, as is often the case in Asiatic marriages she has brought with her a great deal of what is well worth having, such as her own rich dresses, carpets curtains, embroidered cushions, and other things which tend to make a house comfortable. She speaks Armenian and Turkish and writes the former so fast that to day she has written two letters for my one. I would make her write to your wife in that language but you would have little chance of getting the letter read in New York. One of her carpets just fits the centre of our large room which is about twenty four feet by fourteen, with the window, a recess eleven feet by six, this carpet however which is a very rich one, we only put down on high festivals; my old carpets do very well for common wear. Lately she has been busy turning out the wool of the sofa having it and the chintz well washed and restuffing it, so you see she tends to keep my house in order.

I am going on much as usual and altho' I have not gain[ed] much in money by the Gazette I have gained a great deal in consideration both amongst the Persians and Europeans. I do not see so much of the latter as formerly. I was always fond of home and now that I am married I am more so than formerly but I am still received most kindly at the Foreign Missions and thank God I am contented with my lot.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Neeawaran near Tehran, June 22, 1852*

You will see that my letter is dated from Neeawaran. This is a small town some ten miles north of Tehran, and from that city here there is a gentle ascent, the Elbourz mountains rising in precipitous peaks to the height of perpetual snow almost behind the town. The place itself is built in terraces so that going up some of the streets is almost like going up stairs. The King has a summer palace here and as I am obliged to consult the Prime Minister and also sometimes the King himself about articles to be put in the gazette, I am ordered to be here and carry on the work here, all except the actual printing which is done in town. The climate here is most cool and agreeable and I am much better off in this, as thank God in many other respects than I was last year for then I was ordered to carry on the newspaper in town and altho I lived at a village some seven miles out, going backwards and forwards in the great heats, four days in the week, and working hard all day in such a filthy climate as Tehran is during the greater part of three months, was by no means agreeable. My wife is living at

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a village some two miles off but the ride from here, there, is pretty from the orchards along some part of the road and the corn fields (now waving with wheat ripe for the sicle) clover fields and other cultivation. This week I have not got things in order and it being the fast month (Ramazan) it is difficult to do so, but when I get properly settled I hope to arrange to begin work at sunrise and get back home by twelve o'clock.

Do you ever get away from New York and take journeys in the wild parts of the U. S. or are you always at that highly civilized city pray my dear brother let me know something about you and your goings on.

We have not yet pitched all our tents in the orchard I have hired to live in for the next three months; because, as we are going to remain it is much better to have the tents pitched on raised platforms of earth and plaster about a foot high than on the level ground as is done in marching; when all our tents are pitched, ours will be rather a smart little camp and as this year I have thank God a pretty wife of whom I am very fond and who appears to be equally fond of me I hope to pass the next three months agreeably.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tehran, September 22, 1852*

We returned into town from our summer residence on the 5th and the climate is agreeable enough, the days hot but the nights mornings and evenings most delightful. I did not enjoy my residence in the country so much as most years both I and my dear wife having been much out of health. Indeed my health has been so bad that it was with difficulty I could carry on my work, the duties of which are rather arduous I mean editor of the state gazette. Just before the downfall of the late Prime Minister[128] I had got things into such train, that I carried on the business without much difficulty, and from having carried it on well during the absence of the court at Ispahan that is during nearly five months, the Prime Minister and also the King had such confidence in me that all I had to do was to go every Monday morning to the minister and ask him if he had any orders with regard to the weeks Gazette and his invariable answer was no, "you carry on the paper exceedingly well act according to your own judgment," except they had some particular articles to publish and then they were always sent to me in due time for the press, and I went away and brought out the paper to the best of my ability. Now the matter is very different. I publish nothing except the foreign news, without the prime minister's[129] having previously revised it, this gives me a great deal of trouble. I have frequently to spend hours sometimes

[128] Mirza Taki Khan, the Amir-i-Nizam, who proved too honest and able for Persian court taste. A palace intrigue cost him first, his post, and shortly after, his life. See Sykes, *History of Persia*, v. 2, p. 345–346.

[129] Mirza Aga Khan, Itimad-u-Dola, the successtor to Taki Khan.

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nearly the whole of the day, knocking about the ministers ante-room he being engaged and not to be seen, in the meanwhile the printers are waiting and the Gazette must come out on Thursday morning. This gives me great vexation and trouble. One mistake, which has made the minister so cautious was the official announcement in the Gazette of the appointment of a general to the command of eight battalions of infantry before the apointment had taken place! The fact was that the minister who was an intimate friend of the general's had asked the King for the place, the King had given an undecided answer in the mean time the commission was drawn out backed by the minister and only waiting the King's signature. One of the ministers secretaries thinking the thing already finished sent a copy of the commission to me for publication. I thinking all was regular published the thing, the King was out of town and did not get his paper until the evening. Looking it over at night he saw an appointment he had never appointed, got in a fury with his minister and sent him several very sharp notes, in the morning there was enquiry and it was near going hard with me, but I believe the King soon found out who was to blame, and I heard no more about the matter — the general never got his regiments.

One of my old friends [among] the American missionaries settled at Ouroumia has introduced the American Sea Island cotton[130] and some other species. It has answered well in north of Persia and last spring my above named friend, the Revd Mr Stocking[131] sent me some of the seed to present to the King. H. M. ordered me to distribute it, publish the manner of cultivation and write it up in the paper, this I did and from the accounts I have received it appears to be thriving wonderfully; this will be a great benefit to the people, so you see that altho' I only make a bare living myself I am doing some good for my fellow men and my work is not in vain.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tehran, February 21, 1854*

Our dear Father will perhaps have informed you, if I have not written to you, that our child Johnny died on the *3rd* Decr this as you may suppose has caused great grief to us particularly to Anna; and altho' I have not felt the loss so acutely as my wife yet when a man arrives at my time of life and has but one child and that child is taken away from him, he feels the deprivation deeply.

Dr Cormick, with whom you were acquainted in England, and who married my wifes younger sister has been here since last October; his appointment is properly at Tabreez as physician to the Governor of the province, but he was ordered here last autumn and since his arrival has performed some very good

130 One of the many projects of the American missionaries at Urumia.

131 Rev. W. R. Stocking, early associated with Dr. Perkins in the American mission at Urumia.

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cures for one of the King's sons whom the other doctors had given up and other members of the Royal family, and some relations of the Prime minister. This had gained him such a high reputation that it was with difficulty that the King was induced to allow him to return to his post; but remaining here would not have suited Cormick at all, even altho attached to the Kings household, he is making money fast at Tabreez, what with pay, allowances, and the gains of his pharmacy his income can not be much less than fifteen hundred a year of English money.

You never told me whether you ever saw the Count de Sartige formerly Minister for France in Persia and now, or until very lately, holding the same post at Washington, and whether you delivered him the letter I sent you for him, I am sure he would have received you civilly; I see his name in the papers every now and then, and latterly if I mistake not about a quadruple treaty to preserve Cuba,[132] from the clutches of those dashing fellows of the U. S. who wish to incorporate the "lone Star" with their stars and stripes. Of a verity America appears to be the only place where chivalry still lives and flourishes, pity that with the heroic courage and dauntless energy of the knights of old, they have not their polish and courtesy.

Our society at Tehran has much changed of late oweing to the number of the Austrian, Italian and French officers who have come here and entered the service. Many of them are married and so we have a little lady's society, some of them are very accomplished playing and singing like first-rate artistes. Tehran is indeed changed from what it was when I first saw it, there was not then a single European in the place and now there must be near fifty.

I intend to try hard to get to England on a year's leave during this year, I hope to leave this about next May or June and be in England in August. The slow part of the journey will be here from here to Trebizonde as I travel with my wife whom I bring to England with me, we can not go post, but must go only a stage a day, so it will take us near two months to get to Trebizonde, from thence there are steamers and if the war does not prevent us we shall be in England in about twenty days.

[THADDEUS, ARCHBISHOP OF THE ARMENIANS IN PERSIA AND INDIA, TO EDWARD BURGESS] *Julpha, Ispahan, November 8, 1854*

I have the pleasure to inform you, that on the 23rd Ultimo I safely arrived here, and found my people in good state.

[132] There was no formal treaty, but rather an exchange of diplomatic correspondence among Great Britain, France, Spain, and the United States, which finally resulted in a declaration of opinion that Cuba was not to come under the control of any European power other than Spain. See *Great Britain. State papers.* v. 44 (1853–54), p. 114–236.

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During the last few days of my stay in Tehran once I went to your place at Golhak and twice to your house in the Town, to see you and your family in order to give you my blessings and bid you farewell, but I am sorry I was disappointed in not having the pleasure of seeing you, for I have to assure by these few lines that the friendship you showed me and the trouble you took for me during my stay in Tehran are always in my mind and shall be remembered to the last breath of my life. May the Almighty keep your family and your good self many many years in the enjoyment of perfect health and happiness which is always my ardent wish and prayer.

I shall be much obliged by your sending to me a few copies of the Persian paper of Tehran, containing the notification about my affairs at the Court of Persia which was published a few months previous to the last Notification about the same, for the latter I have got a few copies but none of the former.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tehran, December 21, 1854*

Persia is still neutral in the war which rages between Russia and the European powers[133] and I hope she will continue so. Russia has bid fair, for the assistance of Persia, against the Turks, but did not bid quite enough; Persia had great grounds of complaint against Turkey, and an army of fifty or sixty thousand Persians on the Turkish frontier, would have been a powerful diversion in favor of Russia: however Persia has remained quiet; and I am very glad she has done so; as any other course must have been most ruinous to her, except she had joined the allies against Russia; now, much depends upon the fall of Sebastepol for should that place hold out much longer, it is possible, but still very improbable that Persia may still be drawn into a Russian alliance. The Persians and Turks hate one another as the English and French did formerly; and it has required all the British influence and all the skill of Mr Thomson, our Chargé d'affaires to keep them quiet. My position would be a strange one, if Persia were to make war on Turkey, for it would at the present moment be the same thing as making war upon England, for although my employment is altogether civil, yet how could I continue in the service of a state which was at war with my own country.

We have had a great rise in the price of grain here, and barley the chief food of our horses which is usually at about S12/ a quater is now at 28/ this is partly to be attributed to a want of rain last season, and blight in some of the corn districts. The Govt have also made the matter worse by trying to force people to sell at a certain price, in which they have not succeeded, bread also was ordered to be sold at a certain price and the consequence has been that some days the

133 The Crimean War.

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poor people could get no bread at all. There are immense stocks of grain in the districts near this, a great part of which belong to the government, this grain they are bringing in, so I expect we shall have a fall presently. Grain is still most cheap and plentiful in many of the provinces of Persia, but carriage is so expensive in this country where we have no made roads and canals, that the transport often costs far more than the grain is worth.

Our little girl Fanny has had the small pox and thank God has got well over it, it has been an anxious time for Annah and she has born it remarkably well, as she nurses the child herself and as the attack was a severe one, you may imagine what she has had to go through.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO HENRY BURGESS] *Tehran, February 26, 1855*

Since writing to you last month your most kind affectionate and fatherly letter, in answer to mine of the 19th Octr praying you to take care of my dear wife and child in case of your surviving me has arrived. How shall I describe to you the emotions this letter inspired in me, thankfulness to God for having given me so good and kind a father and gratitude to you were my predominant feelings. You appear hurt that I should for a moment have doubted your being, in the event of my wife being left a widow, a kind hearted protector to her, the feeling I had in writing that letter arose from another cause, that is the dislike I had of burthening you with such a serious charge; it being the sacred duty of a son, after he has arrived at the age of manhood to aid assist and support his father. Instead of being burthensome to him, the son ought to labour and undergo privations that the father may live in ease and comfort. How different have been our positions, whilst you have been undergoing privations, I have been enjoying many comparative luxuries.

You will be very glad to learn that, thank God, my health has somewhat improved, I am now altho' still very weak, able to put my horse into a trot or canter without the fear of falling off, a thing I have not done for many months, the disease still continues but its bad symptoms are much mitigated.

I have given in my petition for leave to the Prime Minister, it is addressed direct to the king, and I was about to take it to him direct, but was advised to present it first to the minister. He has agreed to it verbally, but I shall not think myself secure until the King has agreed to my petition and my leave is published in the Gazette. Mr Thomson put in a kind word for me to day in asking the minister to allow me something for my expenses to England, the minister laughed and said "this is rather too bad not only are we going to pay a man for sitting in his house and doing nothing but you ask us to pay his carriage home into the bargain; however tell Burgess to follow up his petition himself, and

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not to try to make interest through others, and I give you my word I will not oppose him."

H. E. Mr Murray[134] has we believe arrived at Kirmanshah and so may be expected here in some twenty days or so, he has come by Busora and Baghdad and it is said travels in great state requiring some two hundred baggage cattle. Of the French Minister we know nothing except that he has quitted France and is on his way. It is thought that both ministers will endeavour to urge Persia to take a decided course against Russia.

The King has ordered an army of 80,000 men to assemble at Sultania and has ordered all Govt servants to be ready to march for the camp with him within one month after the festival of the no-roze (the 21st March). This measure is interpreted differently by different people, some say it is for and some against Russia, a short time will shew.[135]

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tehran, March 14, 1855*

You will perhaps have heard that I am endeavouring to obtain leave to go to England. I have already applied for it and it has been promised me but I shall not think myself safe until my leave is announced in the Gazette which is the custom. We hope to start in about two months from this time. Before that I am afraid I shall not be able to make my arrangements as to the carrying on the government Gazette etc. If I could get my arrears of pay I would engage to start in ten days but this is the great difficulty. Most Europeans on going to Europe to help them with their expenses for the journey and because they do not know well where to leave the things during their absence sell off everything and repurchase on returning. This I have found a very bad plan. They sell things for say £100 by auction and have to replace them when they return and spend £300 in doing so. We shall only sell a few things which are comparatively useless to us, and leave the rest under the care of some friend until our return; when I arrived here with the King in the autumn of '48 my whole property tents, carpets, clothes every thing included was carried on four mules, and one of them was a light load for I had a servant riding upon it. Now I suppose that thirty perhaps forty mules might be required to carry every thing we have, so much do things collect when one sets up housekeeping and remains in a place. We shall travel as lightly as possible but travelling stage by stage from here to Trebizonde, as my wife and child can not unfortunately travel post we must have several loads with us, such as bedding, carpets, tents cooking utensils etc. We shall travel as quickly as possible but I am afraid we shall not get to Trebizonde in less than two months,

134 The new British minister to Persia.

135 Nasir-i-Din finally seized upon a pretext to declare against Britain and Turkey, too late, however, to affect the fortunes of Edward Burgess.

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and for this reason I shall endeavour to have my leave of absence made to date from Tabreez and not from Tehran. This will save me some twenty days or a month in point of time; from Constanople I think of going by way of Trieste and thro' Germany. As there are now steamers from Constanople to Trieste direct, and rail-roads all over the continent, this will I think be the quickest and I am told by far the cheapest route. On the English steamers from Trebizonde to London they do not charge less than £40 for a first class berth. So I am pretty sure that the German route will be the one we shall take.

Our lovely spring weather has commenced but unfortunately I am not often in a condition to enjoy it, my weak health often prevents my moving about or even attending to my duty. The orchards are now most beautiful from the masses of fruit tree blossoms, and the air mild balmy and oderiferous with the spring flowers. I am quite sure the journey will do me good, exercise and freedom from anxiety are the things I want, and I shall try hard to get off from this by the 1st May so as to have the benefit of the cool weather. It is true that at that time here, the days are too hot for travelling, but the mornings and evenings are still delightful, and except for a few stages between this, and near, Tabreez the road from Tehran to Trebizonde passes thro' cool upland districts, the best season for passing which is that at which we hope to be travelling over them.

(This is the last of Edward Burgess's letters which has been preserved. The series of letters will be concluded, in a later instalment, with extracts from an account by Anna Burgess, Edward's wife, of the journey from Tehran and Edward's death and from an early report by Charles Burgess on political and commercial affairs in Persia.)

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